Arjan Dev, when a comparatively larger number of pilgrims visit the temple.

Did the 'final solution', which came in the form of Operation Blue Star, generate the desired momentum with which the 1 Akbar Road group could build a successful campaign for the upcoming elections? It appeared so. The vengeance with which Bhindranwale and his men were eliminated had brought a sense of great relief and satisfaction among a majority of voters. Indira Gandhi's image as a strong leader was restored. But many innocent civilians, including women and children, had to lose their lives in the process.

Lt Gen. K. Sundarji did win the battle for Indira Gandhi, and in March 1986 he became the army chief on General Vaidya's retirement. But at what cost? It was a pyrrhic victory. The developments set in motion as a result of Operation Blue Star led to the loss of a popular prime minister, at a time when the country needed her most. Though Op-2 achieved its objective and the Congress led by Rajiv Gandhi won the November 1984 general elections with an overwhelming majority, Indira Gandhi was assassinated and an anti-Sikh pogrom followed, ensuring that the country, especially the Sikhs, paid a heavy price for no fault of theirs.

Here it would be relevant to examine the pressures on Indira Gandhi which compelled her to approve Operation Blue Star despite being cautioned by a trusted and senior former member of her cabinet like Swaran Singh not to take such a drastic step, and despite Kao's comparatively soft solutions including a heliborne commando operation. Available evidence points the finger at the hawkish Arun Nehru, the politically shrewd M.L. Fotedar, Rajiv Gandhi, who was under their influence, and Arun Singh, who had become a member of the 1 Akbar Road group by that time. Of course, even if we believe that Indira Gandhi was forced to take that decision by this lot, she cannot be absolved of responsibility for what happened. It was she who had allowed extra-constitutional entities to usurp her powers as the prime minster of the country, forcing her to take decisions which she reportedly did not like. The buck stopped with her, and she must be held responsible for all